

# **Materiality, Objects, and Agency: Examples from Archaeology and Anthropology**

## **A Brief Overview for Students**

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While the intricate study of archaeology requires a palette of specializations and perspectives, material culture continues to be the pivotal source of data. Therefore, interpretation of the physical remains plays a fundamental role. This is reflected by decades of vigorous debates (within archaeology) centered on how to think about material remains. Throughout the history of the discipline, various new theoretical approaches have been proposed, employed, altered, and reviewed (Boivin, 2004, 63). Before the advent of ‘Post-Processual’ archaeology, Processual archaeology of the 1960’s regarded material categories as a component of behavioral categories which were functionally determined by the social and biological systems within which they operated (Barrett, 2001, 146). In direct contrast, the ‘post-Processualism,’ academic movement of the later 1980’s has since emphasized the notion that prehistoric human action should not be viewed as fully determined by external conditions (as ‘extra-somatic means of adaptation’). In addition, post-Processualists asserted that prehistoric material should no longer be viewed merely as static signs that represent social groups, systems, or economic formations (Buchli, 2004, 181).

Greatly influential to this paradigm shift, and of recent recognition, has been the concept of ‘agency.’ Bringing agency into archaeological interpretation permits a far-reaching shift in the way material culture and the past can be interpreted. This is because agency allows archaeologists to conceptualize beyond merely the interactions that occur between functionally related variables (Johnson, 1987, 191). Agency cannot be defined without effort. In terms of human- related qualities, ‘agency’ has been described in terms of consciousness, intentionality, self-governed movement, and volition (Robb, 2005, 131). Although humans play a critical role, the concept of agency is not focused solely upon individuals acting as ‘self-promoting aggrandizers’ overflowing with intentionality (Dobres & Robb, 2005, 162). It is more comprehensible as the search for meaningful human action within historically-based social conditions (Robb, 2005, 131). This pursuit

for agency should not, however, be confused with the archaeological identification of individuals (Johnson, 1987, 190).

One highly influential figure on the philosophical nature of agency has been Giddens (1979), who stressed that humans entered contexts as prior informed by experience. This prior knowledge includes possessing a sense of what is appropriate, painful, or rewarding in differing circumstances. In other words, a social actor can know a great deal about how their own society operates and is more or less capable of asserting or manipulating social rules within a given social situation (Johnson, 1987, 191). Giddens' interpretation of the relationship between people and objects involves a duality-- human actions are informed by a social structure-- these actions then turn and alter the same existing social structure (Wobst, 200, 40). As one theoretical archaeologist has stated, 'agency straddles the line between human consciousness as a source and a product of action, and stresses the dual natures of action as both recreating the actor's consciousness and having an effect on the external world' (Robb, 2005, 131). This duality permits a more open-ended and indeterminate way of thinking that emphasizes a methodology greatly applicable to archaeologists: the concentration on material as the product of negotiated social contingencies (Buchli, 2004, 181).

In recent archaeological literature there has been an appeal to demonstrate agency in 'how material things structure human life not metaphysically, but in concrete ways which cross the traditional conceptual boundaries of subject-object, active-passive, and agent-environment' (Robb, 2005, 131). Although it has been widely accepted that objects do not appear in our world in an entirely unmediated form (Barrett, 2001, 147), current theorists are broadening this concept to include the material world as not just central to social reproduction, but actually constituting social relations in the creation of meaning (Dobres & Robb, 2005, 162). This implies that we must attribute agency to *both* subjects and objects as we encounter people and things in some *mutually constitutive* sense (Rowlands, 2005, 198). For example, meaning can be discerned through transactions objectified in material form. In the modern world, a birthday gift of a pen is not purely functional, but is symbolically tied to the person and intentionality behind the gift- giving action. Whether the pen is used when needed may depend on how a person *feels* about the pen and what the pen is associated with.

Within archaeology, this form of materialism (or the study of material objects beyond mere functionality) is crucial in that it approaches archaeological concepts such as identity through the nature in which the actions of ‘making and doing’ constitute both consciousness and things as a process (Rowlands, 2005, 198). In other words, an object is a deposit of practical categories as well as categories that suggest a way of ‘being and thinking’ beyond simply the symbolical (Kus & Raharijaona, 2005, 241). Because of this, objects form reference points (and thus provide their own sense of agency) in the choices humans make of how to act (Wobst, 2000, 41). Consequently, the human ‘cognitive ordering’ of the material world causes an actor to pursue only such a strategy with reference to some pre-existing external structure or *habitus* at any given moment in time (Johnson, 1987, 192). This is not to say that humans are not in control of their material world, but rather to emphasize the need to question whether they are motivated by free will alone.

If one accepts that material culture is ‘active’ beyond functionality, all actions reproduce a multitude of structures which perpetuate social relations and cultural values regardless of the proximate reason or intent. As social beings, humans can only act within an understood and accepted field of action in which material culture intervenes to structure through the categories, institutions, and beliefs associated with the physical world. It must be assumed that material in the past was given meaning which projected ‘correct’ fields of usage, imposed future action, and played central roles in social relations just as in the modern world of today’s social theorists. For archaeologists, this means that past human use of artifacts should always be viewed as being structured according to the ‘social field of action’ within which artifacts may have embedded. This ultimately depended on the specific perception and beliefs of the people affected and most importantly; some of these aspects may be visible in the archaeological record (Robb, 2005, 133).

### **Differences in Terminology and Methodology**

Multiple approaches have inevitably employed many different terms for the same general concept in the consideration of agency for humans and objects. In clarifying the difference between object or human-related agency there has been the use of ‘conscious

vs. ‘*effective*’ agency and ‘*primary*’ vs. ‘*secondary*’ agency. ‘Conscious’ agency has been used to describe human intentional and conscious action, while ‘effective’ agency has been labeled the ability to shape future actions (Robb, 2005, 132). ‘Primary’ agency refers to human action, while objects are labeled to exert ‘secondary’ agency in events instigated by humans (Gell, 1998, 20). Gell (1998) has been a fundamental voice in the specific study of objects and agency. In his explanation of ‘secondary’ agency he has stated ‘that an object is thought to have an emanation or manifestation of agency, a mirror, a vehicle, or channel of agency and hence a source of potent experiences of the ‘co-presence.’ The agency of the material world can often act as ‘distributed personhood’ (Gell, 1998, 21). The objectification in artefact form he states, is ‘how social agency manifests and realizes itself, via the proliferation of fragments of ‘primary’ intentional agents in their ‘secondary’ artefactual forms’ (Gell, 1998, 21). Put another way, objects or archaeological artifacts as ‘secondary’ social agents have the nature of their agency stemming from their status as ‘objective embodiments’ of the power of intentional beings (Rowlands, 2005, 198).

This concept has been further explored by Knappett (2004), with his use of the term *affordances* in the ‘codependency of mind and matter’ in terms of what he sees as three fundamental issues: indirect or direct relationality, transparency, and sociality. The basis of this stance is that humans think *through* matter in different ways (Knappett, 2004, 50). Relationality concerns the changing agency of an object as a direct result of differing contexts. To use his example: a chair is ordinarily best used for sitting, but in some contexts it may be best used to prop open a door, beat someone over the head with, or as fuel for a fire, etc. Transparency relates to how obvious a function or use of material is in certain situations (Knappett, 2004, 46). For example, someone from the forests of Papua New Guinea may not instantly recognize what a ‘shoe-horn’ is used for, whereas they may instantly recognize that a wooden chair is used for sitting. In this way the affordance of a wooden chair is more transparent than that of a shoehorn. Sociality comes into play when a situation involves more than one person and the affordances of material may be negotiated, contested, or shared. In some cases the affordances of an object may be different to each individual based on their personal perspective (Knappett, 2004, 47).

In yet another variation of terminology, Wobst (2000) calls human artifacts ‘material inferences’ or ‘material intentions to change.’ He believes ‘agency via artefacts is an interference that helps us imagine individuals and groups as more than mechanistic robots. It produces the templates for visualizing practical and impractical reason, utopias, and morals. Material interferences engender, envision, constitute, contest, and contain the agent, and they help reify subject and object alike ‘ (Wobst, 2000, 42). For a similarly described stance Robb (2005) employs the term ‘extended artefact’ (Robb, 2005, 134). In an extension of this explanation, Renfrew (2001) points out that for symbols-- X representing Y in C (context) is not always true and points to symbols which do not represent something themselves but are active. He refers to these symbols as *constitutive symbols*. Constitutive symbols ‘create the very possibility of certain activities’. Within archaeological theory, Renfrew’s main argument is that often the active material symbol takes precedence over the concept. One example of his is the modern concept of money, which historically could not exist without the material symbol, and which even today currently plays an obvious role as a constitutive symbol (Figure 1, drawn by author) of the possibility of multiple actions and opportunities (Renfrew, 2001, 130). Another analogy from contemporary Western society could be that of the female obsession of shopping for clothes. It is not so much that the clothes are needed for warmth or cover, but that they represent to each buyer such things as embodied imaginative possibilities of use, vehicles for future social contexts, or status signifiers (Figure 2, drawn by author).

Just as archaeology employs many different terms to discuss agency, there is also a great variation in methodologies. The archaeological record is neither static nor homogenous and because of this there is a genuine need for a diverse range of approaches (Barrett, 2001, 147). The usefulness of each depends upon the context employed. Overlap of theory is inherent in most approaches and a mixture of theoretical strategies has proven to be the most useful way to study archaeological material. Some of the more popular genres of approach are those of ‘materialization’, ‘phenomenology’, ‘embodiment’, ‘social/symbolic technological’, and those that are known as ‘contextual.’

The concept of materialization is known as the transformation of beliefs, values, myths, and ideas into a physical reality. Materialization can take many forms such as a domestic building, ceremonial activity, symbolic object, or political monument. Within

archaeology, one recent use of materialization has been for the study of past political ideologies (DeMarrais et al., 1996, 16). In particular, great attention has been given to the materialization of ideology by a dominant group to achieve a status of shared values and beliefs that specifically legitimizes their status and power. One way this is thought to have occurred is through the direct association of a certain part of the material world with an elite lineage or deity in the materialization of a social position (DeMarrais, 1996, 18). For example, monuments like that of the massive temples of Mesoamerica are thought to have made it possible to extend an elite's ideology beyond a local group to a broader population to create a shared political culture. The physical world plays an important role in that it is used to express elite ideology (monuments, artwork) as well as legitimate prestige and status when resources that are rare (precious metals) are controlled by elites and consequently become highly valued (DeMarrais et al., 1996, 16, 17).

Phenomenology focuses on bodily movement and sensory experience (Dobres & Robb, 2005, 163). In these types of analysis techniques of the body are critically noted as techniques and experiences of the self-consciousness. Seen through this theoretical lens--social identity, parameters, and reality are constructed and negotiated through the process of everyday living formed through experiences of the bodily acts of 'making or doing' sometimes referred to as 'performance characteristics.' This approach is supported by Marx's view that consciousness is a product of everyday living and the form it takes is 'not a natural fact but a material practice' (Rowlands, 2005, 199). In this way everyday actions (those in which simple tasks are repetitions of processes) are crucial to the confirmation of personal existence as part of a larger totality (Rowlands, 2005, 201). For instance, the repeated process and experience of the smell, feel, and skill of gathering a rare fresh herb every morning when the sun is at a specific height may be a fundamental feature of a person or group's shared feelings about sacredness and/or identity. Agents therefore recognize a coming into being of their own existence in an engagement with the remaking of the everyday world itself, as these practices are worked through with reference to interrelationships in a complex material universe and in the co-presence of others (Barrett, 2001, 152). As phenomenological approaches are difficult to read from the archaeological record, this type of emphasis has been viewed as giving much literature from this genre a somewhat 'existential' flavor (Renfrew, 2001, 122).

The theoretical concept of embodiment is very similar to that of phenomenology in that the importance of the 'experiential' is emphasized. Embodiment involves the drawing of analogues between technological processes (in which materials are transformed) into bodily and socio-cultural transformations (death, gestation, social initiation). Here again, the relationship between the body and objects is more than physical and is embedded in social practice (Rowlands, 2005, 201). One example known from ethnography is the process of pottery creation as being associated to the process of giving birth. Symbols in material form have been known ethnographically and from modern times to derive directly from their relationship to the human body. For example, in many cultures things that are red in color are signifiers of such things as danger and death because the color of blood and bleeding is red and is associated with wounds and physical hurt. Thus, things that are red such as poppies, ochre, and red flags may become associated with these concepts because of this human physical trait. Based on the idea that material is 'only meaningful by virtue of the interaction with it by human agents, which is in turn enabled and limited by the capacities and potentialities of the human body,' both phenomenology and the concept of embodiment can be useful methods of elucidating agency (Boivin, 2004, 64).

Recent attention in social, anthropological, and archaeological theory on a technological approach (which searches for social and symbolic meaning) has provided explanations that employ both phenomenology and embodiment. In this approach, meaning is seen as affecting the entire process of technological innovation in a fundamental way. Cultural factors are believed to shape technical invention based on what the cultural perception of existing elements of material cultures includes. Meaning associated with the physical world is thought to at times result in innovation and other times to prevent it, regardless of need or practicality (Lemonnier, 1993, 25). This is based on the idea that people live for years with and by their chosen techniques that deeply influence their everyday life, comfort, and social relations, as well as the meaning they read into the world. In other words, their technical choices of the time may not seem of any great importance compared with the greater evolution of human technology, but they are nevertheless a key element for the understanding of peoples' life and culture. Above all, the investigation of technology is based on the idea that meaning and its relation to

techniques is the ‘inescapable means’ of any adoption, innovation, or change in material culture (Lemonnier, 1993, 25, 26).

By archaeological terms, a “contextual analysis” in general looks for fine-grained actions such as competition, emulation, reinterpretation, resistance, or dissent within historically situated contexts (Dobres & Robb, 2005, 163). The result of the post-Processualist movement, contextualism is a theoretical umbrella that encompasses the gamut of methodologies that involve agency theory. A contextual approach allows actions to be the result of past and future associated meanings and intentions between both human actors and socially-laden objects. Contextual approaches tend to avoid cross-cultural generalizations and strictly empirical explanations of functionality. In addition, they also assert the need to critically reflect on the contexts of the archaeologists *themselves* (Hodder, 1986, 154).

### **Ethnographic Examples**

An ethnographic example from the nineteenth-century demonstrates how the physical properties of material items have a bearing on the ways that they are incorporated into symbolic and social strategies. This is not to say material culture should be regarded as simply constraining or determinate, but rather as a field of possibilities reproduced by the practices which occupy that field; an analogy of this would be language where structural (physical for objects) conditions control cause and effect in the same way in which conversations are the consequence of grammar (Barrett, 2001, 150). During Victorian times Western European clothing styles for men not only signified that men were serious, active, and aggressive, it also allowed them physically in action to be so. In contrast, the heavy constricting and complex dresses (sometimes resembling ambulatory wedding cakes) worn by women not only symbolized their frivolousness, inactivity, delicate and submissive nature, but also produced such behavioral attributes (Figure 3, [www.costumes.org/history](http://www.costumes.org/history)). Thus, material substance does not only configure the relationship between signifier and signified, but can also influence social relationships themselves. This is a good example of how the involvement of mind, matter, and body in the formation of the social world is a complex mix of cognition and physicality (Boivin, 2004, 65).

The following is an example of how in a particular period or human group, there can always be found people exhibiting technical behaviors that do not correspond with any logic of material efficiency (Lemonnier, 1993, 24). In addition to the physical attributes of material, it has been stressed that the processes of materiality (the giving of meaning to material) are of greater or equal significance to the object itself (Buchli, 2004, 185). The reindeerman of Northeastern Finland illustrate these notions in a technological study by Ingold, (1993) (Ingold, 1993, 103). Ingold noticed there were two main types of lasso used to capture reindeer, the *vimpa* (Figure 4, Ingold, 1993, 120) and the *suopunki* (Figure 5, Ingold, 1993, 111). The *vimpa* (stick with rope apparatus) is used by all reindeermen regardless of regional location during the gathering and marking of reindeer in the summer and the *suopunki* (traditionally thrown rope) used to be used predominantly by all reindeerman during autumn herding season. Recently, modern technology such as the introduction of transportable fences (Figure 6, Ingold, 1993, 121) used to make the herding of reindeer more efficient has left less space to throw a traditional *suopunki* lasso (Ingold, 1993, 119). The southern region of Ingold's study area is much more densely populated and connected by roadways which allow the use of the transportable fences via truck bed, while the people of the northern region do not use transportable fences as their reindeer are not always reachable by road. Consequently, the *vimpa* has all but displaced the *suopunki* in the south since the portable fence technique of herding reindeer leaves a lot less space to throw a *suopunki* and thus, the *vimpa* is more practical (Ingold, 1993, 118).

Practicalities aside, Ingold noticed that reindeermen from the north still used the older and more traditional *suopunki* even when at a herding event in a small enclosed area where the *suopunki* was much more time consuming to use than the *vimpa*. Although they demonstrate the knowledge and skill of *vimpa* use during summer marking, they still choose the *suopunki* at all times when herding. When a southern man aids in a northern roundup, they bring the *suopunki* or will sometimes go barehanded than use the *vimpa*; this is most likely due to the fact that the southern reindeermen have probably lost the skill and practice of throwing the *suopunki* (Ingold, 1993, 122). One man from a leading reindeer owning family of northern association, whom has married into a southern family, always uses the *vimpa* down south. Upon return to the north, he

instead always uses the suopunki to work with his brothers (despite his quiet insistence the vimpa is a superior tool) (Ingold, 1993 123,). Ingold believes that identity plays a strong role in technological choice as the suopunki represents full participation in reindeer husbandry by the north, which has larger herds, than the small numbers from the south where many reindeer men are new and amateur. The increase in skill needed for the use of the traditional lasso creates ‘work conditional on the possession of traditional skills that is difficult for the inexperienced to acquire.’ In this manner, the difference lies in as much the degree of skill involved as in the objective properties of the instruments themselves. For these reindeer men, lasso choice is not a function simply of their material use, but of the social relations, affiliations, and identities of the human users. Technological choice is dictated as much by the considerations of who a reindeer man feels he is as it is by the mechanical effect he desires to achieve (Ingold, 1993, 124). The agency of the lasso itself is apparent since the reindeer men apprehend the material world and structure it culturally to create a world of things. These things then have a ‘quasi-independent existence which reciprocity structures’ how those who relate to them live and act much in the same way other people do (Robb, 2005, 133).

### **Examples from Archaeological Contexts**

The most useful case studies have been stated to be those of areas where the contextual information and temporal clarity afforded by the archaeological evidence are detailed enough to explain variability in terms of agency, while at the same time allowing enough depth of time to be able to link substantive conclusions to broader, long-term structures and changes within the archaeological record (Johnson, 1987, 209). In such a case study from Bronze Age Denmark, there is an argument that highly segmented chiefdoms did not arise until the ‘male chiefly hierarchy’ was directly symbolized (‘materialized’) by metallic weapons of war. Prior to the introduction of metal, burial mounds divided the landscape into cultural regions possibly owned by local chiefs. They materialized a social hierarchy and a religious sanctity which was legitimated in the transformed landscape to a world owned and controlled by chiefs whose rights to leadership was rooted in their ancestry (DeMarrais, 1996, 22). However, stratification was meager compared to that of later periods; the archaeological forms of prestige

(materialization in burial) changed relatively little from Funnel Beaker through to Single Grave type society. It is not until the presence of metallurgy that greater differentiation in terms of ranking becomes apparent.

It is thought that bronze technology allowed the materialization of a hierarchal ideology to institutionalize highly ranked society in the Early Bronze Age on the assumption that chiefs controlled long-distance trade routes and thus the procurement of metal, retaining exclusive rights of access to these metal weapons over the rest of the population (DeMarrais et al., 1996, 23). Metal as a substance was thus in the position to be regarded as a symbol of power and domination tied to the elite restrictively. Production of stone weaponry (though similarly associated with warrior power) prior to this had been impossible to control as stone is readily available. Although many swords were made locally, chiefly swords required lost wax molding which is an intricate and difficult process in which it is assumed only a few trades people would have known (Figure 7, DeMarrais et al., 1996, 22). It is thought that these artisans may have been controlled by the elite through patronage or ownership as attached specialists. Archaeologically, the absence of their debris shows how spatially restricted their production must have been. Thus, chiefs solidified their control over subsistence production and exchange through the direct supervision of sword production (DeMarrais, 1996, 22).

This case study is interesting in terms of gender as well, as females had decorative bronze brooches available to display status. However, it is argued that because their production was not complicated and therefore not easily controllable, females were not able to capture the same prestige as men within the materialization of their display items (DeMarrais et al., 1996, 22). Thus, the argument is made that bronze objects did not allow greater stratification simply as the result of their functional properties in war; it was their agency as socially embedded symbols of the dominant ideology that allowed this to occur.

To link this study to an even larger picture, Renfrew (2001) makes a similar argument based on the 'social life of things' in that the 'human revolution' (the emergence of the human species) was not linked to a series of rapid change in the archaeological record, but that many of these changes occurred with the onset of

sedentism as it allowed higher production of deliberate ‘commodities’ for exchange. It is his belief that it is within sedentary society that the process of human engagement with the material world ‘takes on a new form and permits the development of new modes of interaction with the material world permitting the ascription of symbolic meaning to material objects’ (Renfrew, 2001, 130). From these objects came a ‘new concept of value’ which made possible the development of other aspects of human society such as the development of social hierarchies, and the sustained exercise of power. These value-laden objects made possible more generalized concepts of status and gender. This argument is based on the fact that ‘complete expression’ of these concepts is found broadly in the sedentary societies of the Old and New World (Renfrew, 2001, 138).

He also feels that the materialization of Bronze Age Denmark of which DeMarrais et al. (1996) speak of is ‘not the embodiment in material culture of pre-existing concepts; it is hypostatic union of idea and material’ (Renfrew, 2001, 136). Consequently, bronze weapons were ‘objective embodiments of the *power or capacity to will their use*’ (Gell, 1998, 21). Returning to his concept of the constituted symbol, he believes that bronze metallurgy did not reflect the contemporary culture so much as act as a constitutive symbol imbued with innovative concepts of agency.

## **Conclusion**

As one archaeologist puts it, ‘the nexus between human agency and material culture has proved remarkably slippery’ (Robb, 2005, 131). No longer can the Cartesian dualism of the subject standing completely separate from the inanimate object (the result of the cultural process of ‘purification’ from the Enlightenment) that created the ontologically separate zones of human vs. non-human be understood as the best explanation of human reality (Rowlands, 2005, 198). As we can see from modern, ethnographic, and archaeological examples, the material world is not a blank slate upon which is inscribed any old narrative; it is a physicality which resists and enables, shutting down some alternative plots, and opening up others. Minds are not abstract but embodied, and the potential of the world is recognized through their engagement with a material environment that does not just receive, but also asserts helping to sculpt the forms that human societies take (Boivin, 2004, 64). Archaeologists have always understood that

material culture is instrumental to how people create, experience, give meaning to, negotiate, and transform their world—but rather than analyze in only pragmatic and functional terms, it is now becoming more appreciated that material culture is and was in the past meaningful to the degree that it could even “act back” on its makers and users with its own form of agency (Dobres & Robb, 2005, 161).

So now that it is become clear how vital the concept of agency is for archaeology, is there hope for it being effectively employed in the field? There has certainly been a concern in academic literature over the lack of fit between theorizing agency and actually applying this methodology to the past. Agency in some ways has been seen as ‘too large a concept to link directly to specific understandings of prehistory’ and many archaeologists now invoke agency as a philosophical basis for making sense of the human condition while still employing analytic methodologies designed for previous generations of questions (Dobres & Robb, 2005, 160). Considering how ‘active and rich’ in social meaning that material culture is, (complicated, context-specific, and dialectic) it is questioned whether anyone should bother excavating and destroying sites if the finds are so deeply under-interpreted and conformed to a methodological framework not designed for the task (Dobres & Robb, 2005, 162). Dobres and Robb (2005) have recently called for a development of an ‘agency-oriented reading’ for each specific body of archaeological material through a task-suited middle range interpretive methodology that draws on the various genres of theoretical approach (Dobres & Robb, 2005, 164).

If the ways in which agencies were produced and transformed through their inhabitation of material conditions was effectively investigated and interpreted, archaeology would not only reaffirm the historical significance of the material details it recovers, but it would also contribute significantly to the development of the social theory which it has chosen to employ (Barrett, 2001, 162). Material properties are clearly an active component of the structural properties of the social system of both the present and the past. Human action/practice/agency draws upon memory, past experience, expectations, and desires recognized in the physical (malleability and resistance) as well as the emotional and symbolic associations of material. As we have seen, the nature of a society is reproduced and transformed through the various outcomes, both intentional and unintentional, of the practices which the material world facilitates (Barrett, 2001,150).

We have much to learn by a fuller examination of the process of engagement by which human individuals and societies involve themselves with the material world in constructing their own social realities (Renfrew, 2001, 138). Agency clearly has a critical role in archaeology to help us access a more complete, active, multi-vocal, complicated, and meaningful world of the past.

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# **Late Antique to Carolingian Europe**

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